instead he went to Ljubljana to be trained as a watchmaker. There he met his future wife and returned to a small town near his native village. By then, he was a citizen of the Italian Kingdom, as Italy got a chunk of western Slovenia as a reward for turning its back on its former ally, Austria, during World War I. (This is how Vrhpolje, together with the famous battle at Frigidus, ended up in Italy.) A few years later, the Fascists came into power in Italy. In the ethnically mixed territory of the Trieste/Trst region, the Fascist ideology, often laughed at, translated into a very real terror directed against ethnic Slovenians, a long time before anywhere else in pre-World War II Europe suffered anything similar: the Slovenian language was banned from public use and the church became the only place where it was tolerated. Fascist militias ravaged villages in the wider Trieste/Trst region, molesting the local Slovenian population: during one such expedition, a Slovenian musician was forced to drink machine oil until he died. There were documented cases of Italian teachers spitting into the mouths of children that dared to speak Slovenian in school. Scores of Slovenian opponents of the Fascist regime were imprisoned, tortured or confined to remote parts of Italy. Four members of the secret Slovenian resistance movement were executed – those that a century later would be honoured by the Italian President. This was most probably the first antifascist movement in Europe and Slovenians in Italy the first victims of Fascism in Europe. In 1938, the movement even came close to assassinating Mussolini at Kobarid, site of the famous World War I battle known as Caporetto in Italian. According to a source, British intelligence convinced the man commissioned for the task not to proceed, allegedly to save the Munich accords.[80]

In those years, Fascism inspired the then little-known Slovenian writer Vladimir Bartol to produce *Alamut*, a fascinating story set in medieval Iran and depicting a militant religious sect. The work, which is above all a thinly veiled criticism of totalitarian systems and ideological violence, Fascism in particular, was rediscovered in the aftermath of 9/11 due to what many saw as a prophetic account of Islamic fundamentalism and terrorism. In 2005, the book was included by the Spanish daily *El Pais* among the 50 greatest works of historical fiction and was published in English as well (Scala House Press, 2004).

Another artist of that time, Tone Kralj, a painter, gave himself the task of